‘ You never know’:

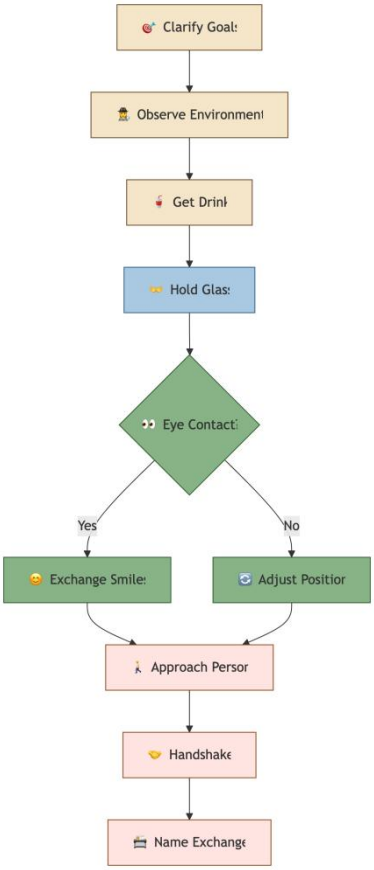
How Hope is fostering in ritualized Business Networking Events in London

Imagine yourself, on weekday evenings after work, as the streets get busier and the tube grows more crowded, you’re one of the many people stepping into fancy pubs across Zone 1 ---walking in, about to join me at a series of different business networking events. You’re about to meet an “Investor & Non-Executive Director,” “visionary entrepreneurs,” or “journalists from top publications.” What will you gain from this? Perhaps it will be described as “both business and socially fun, with a different vibe and energy.” Perhaps it’s “the perfect chance to expand your network, exchange ideas, and forge meaningful relationships.” Or maybe it’ s about “fostering valuable business and professional connections that can propel your career forward.”

These are the promises written in event ads ---clear, exciting, and full of opportunity. But what actually happens inside? What do people really do, say, and hope for? Through repeated gestures, introductions, and certain unspoken rules, something more subtle takes place: a ritualized process of seeking connection, recognition, and future possibility. Based on nine times fieldwork experience, this ethnographic account explores how hope is not simply expressed, but carefully fostered through these ritualized processes.

The events are held in upscale pubs. The bartenders are dressed in suits.You walk up to the area behind the belt, say your name, and someone from the team ticks it off on an A4 paper guest list. The women wear heels, elegant dresses made of silk, or sharply tailored suits in fashionable cuts. Their exposed skin shimmers with glittery body lotion, and they carry delicate handbags that match their outfit in color or texture. The space around their ears, necks, and shoulders is occupied by jewelry that looks expensive — not necessarily loud, but deliberate. The men are in suits, shirts, or camel and black turtlenecks. Their leather shoes shine. Even when the venue feels overheated, they never remove what they've carefully chosen to wear. Instead, they let their shirts quietly soak up the sweat, or allow it to run invisibly beneath their clothes. I wore sneakers and carried a heavy school backpack stuffed with notebooks and a large sports water bottle. In the restroom, I often found myself next to other women swapping into heels, carefully checking their makeup in the mirror, while I was just fixing my wind-blown hair after the tube ride ---sometimes even forgetting to remove my LSE student ID card hanging from my neck. I saw others adjusting their outfits, glancing at themselves in the mirror ---slightly excited, slightly nervous, maybe even a little proud. They were about to embark on the unpredictable adventure of a business networking event. Some things could be anticipated, but who they would meet was always uncertain.

People seemed a bit puzzled by why I was there. At first, the events thrilled me. But I also hated how everything seemed to be measured ---how people judged one another based on clothes, jobs, neighborhoods, or the perceived potential of their field. Whenever I said I am a social anthropology student, people quickly lost interest. Some politely nodded and soon excused themselves. Their words varied: "I should get another drink," "Good luck with your research," "Nice to meet you" ---but the message was clear. I felt like the ugly duckling, awkwardly mimicking the swans ---learning how to order drinks, how to reach out and shake hands gracefully. I would stand at the edge of a conversation circle, pretending to be mysterious, waiting for others to speak first so I could adjust my self-introduction ---thinking carefully about which part of my story to lead with, what might catch people’ s attention, and how to explain why I was even there. I was afraid of showing my nervousness, of being seen as inexperienced. After attending around four events, I became more confident in how to talk to people. I suddenly realized that some parts of this world could be learned, practiced, even trained.



（These are the basic steps people follow in social spaces. Nobody says them out loud. But even if it's your first time, you'll understand by watching others. ）

In my first few events, everything looked exactly like the stereotype ---people showcasing status, speaking in polished pitches, scanning one another for value. I felt disappointed. Weren't fieldwork and anthropology supposed to challenge stereotypes, not confirm them? I silently shouted in my heart: Why does this feel so predictable? My research is not meant to reinforce clichés ---it's meant to question them. My fieldwork focused on business networking events in London, all held at night. Each event was slightly different ---some had guest speakers, others had pitch sessions, and some were women-only. But all of them centered on business. Starting from the third event, I noticed how shrewd people could be ---but also how contradictory it felt, because beneath that calculation, there was still sincerity. People were strategic, but also human.

Even though business networking events never fully repeat themselves ---the people change, the venues change ---certain elements recur across all events. These non-human things ---name tags, drink tokens, LinkedIn QR codes ---are not just passive details. Actor-Network Theory views both humans and non-humans as actors that together shape social interactions through networks of relations. These materials shape interactions, influence atmospheres, and anchor social rituals. Through them, one can almost visualize the familiar scene before it begins. As actors, they help make the event more ritualized.

In this short and fast-paced environment, sincerity isn' t the point. What matters is whether your actions are correct, appropriate, smooth, and complete. No one tells you what to do--- but there' s a set of unspoken rules that everyone seems to follow. These unspoken rules do two things: first, they ritualize the event structure; second, they show that hope is not pre-given, but is fostered in the moment through ritualized interaction. These structured routines help people keep their hope alive and reinforce their sense of identity. Goffman (1967) describes everyday social interactions as ritualized performances that follow unspoken norms and serve to maintain social order. Therefore, in networking events, these ritualized interactions function as interaction rituals. People may not consciously notice them, but they help create comfort, recognition, and leave the door open for future possibilities.

Efficiency is another very important unspoken rule in networking events. It depends on two things: how many people you talk to, and how you present yourself in a way that makes others want to stay in touch

with you. For example, an African girl from Peckham introduced herself to me quickly, saying, “I’ve already rehearsed my introduction three times.” This was only 40 minutes into the event, and she had already connected with three different groups.

Priya, a business student from India studying at Queen Mary University, told me she doesn’t want to go back to India. Even though finding a job in the UK is tough, she wants to stay. I noticed her moving from one group to another, switching every 10 minutes or so. That’s when I asked her the question.

“Have you talked to almost everyone tonight?” I asked.

“Yes, pretty much. There are still a few I haven’t had a chance to speak with, but I exchanged contact info with them before they left—we’ll follow up later.”

And about halfway through every event, the host always reminds the group: “How many people have you met so far? How many LinkedIns have you added? Don’t waste tonight!” Some hosts even set goals, like “You must connect with five new people tonight.”

Sometimes, I test how well someone is networking by asking for help. I’ll point to a random person across the room and say, “I haven’t had a chance to talk to that guy—do you know what he does?” Priya replied like bullet points: “He works in fashion, used to make films and music videos, and now he’s doing investment.” Her answer followed a common structure people use when introducing others: profession, identity, and past experience. These responses reflect not only what people remember from quick chats, but also what they consider important. When you repeat your life story again and again to different people, you start to refine it. You learn to rearrange the details based on how people react. The version of your future self that you imagine is shaped by how you narrate your past.

Exiting and Leaving Space: 1. Exit directly and leave while everyone is still talking 2. In contrast to the first type, you will greet the people present (shake hands/hug) "I am very happy to see you today + the reason for leaving/no need to say the reason, just say that you are leaving now + hope to keep in touch in the future/see you again in other events", and then leave. Aled,the IT designer, wearing a black peaked cap. He is a designer working for a trading bank. When the staffs began to clean up the chairs. He said “I has a three-and-a-half-year-old daughter, I have to go, but it was so nice to talk with you.” He mentioned his daughter during the conversation, so everyone showed pretty understood. The girl next to me, instantly said: “oh, do you have Linkin?” “Yes.” and they start follow each other. By using this exiting way can impress again, and it would be another chance to let you request others contacts smoothly, properly.

3. Between the first and second types, neither leaving silently nor attracting everyone's attention, use eye contact/gestures/body movements to signal someone in the conversation, and the other people will also use implicit letting go to indicate that you are ready to leave. This describes a chat scene with three or more people. The first and third types do not exist in a one-on-one scene. Directly ask for something and end the conversation, or be a little more tactful, "I'm going to get a glass of wine" "I'm going to talk to A, catch you later" In this case, everyone know that they will not catch you later, but they still say it. There are always occasions to meet again in an event, which may be in a different conversation, when getting a glass of wine, in the bathroom, or when everyone leaves the event together. But once there is such a sentence, the atmosphere when the two meet again will be more friendly, leaving enough room and space for subsequent unknown things and opportunities.

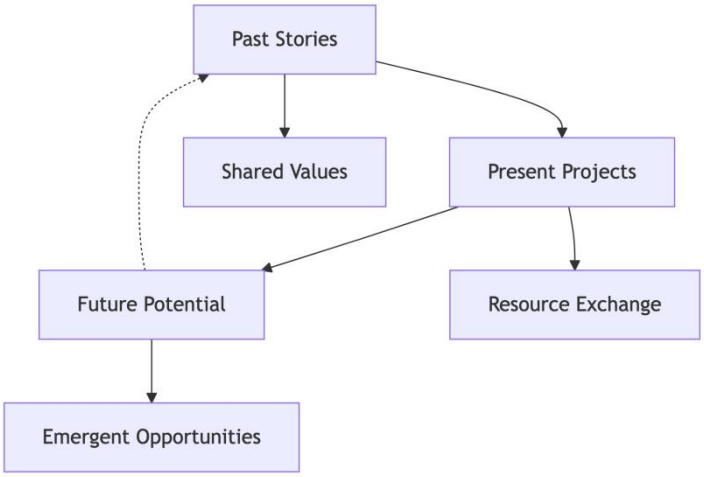
These are common strategies that people use to keep the social game going. Everyone plays in their own way, because they believe that maybe, in the future, someone they meet might be helpful, or they might cross paths again in another form. So they leave space for future possibilities. They follow the rules to keep the game smooth and enjoyable, to make sure the vibe feels right between them.The scripted yet casual behaviors in networking events can be seen as “doctrinal rituals” （Whitehouse, 2021） — they

are repetitive, low-intensity, and designed to foster trust and a sense of belonging in large, fluid groups. And only when that connection feels good do they start imagining a future relationship.

Practicing the Future: Hope as Method in Networking

Returning to the young girl from Peckham mentioned above. She was a Black girl with long red braids. She never avoided eye contact. When talking to her, I could feel that she was comfortable in this kind of setting—confident, quick, smooth. But I could also sense something uncertain in her eyes, a kind of youthful vulnerability.

I knew her because she jumped into a conversation I was having with the IT designer. She simply said, "I want to join you—I hope you don't mind," and effortlessly became part of the exchange. The designer soon finished his part, and the topic shifted to Cleopatra. She spoke quickly, introducing her own life story. She was 23. Her parents brought her to London when she was 18 and gave her an English name. She dropped out of school in junior high or high school. Now, she is starting her own business. In this short interaction, she brought her past into the present to answer the classic opening question: "What brings you here?" Her story helped others decide whether or not they wanted to build a future connection with her. This is how networking compresses time. Past, present, and future overlap in a single moment. You know nothing about someone's past, but you meet them in the now, and immediately make a judgment about the future. These overlapping times create a space where hope can be fostered. Even if the outcomes remain uncertain, people continue to come, to talk, to imagine.



(How past stories bring present and future together)

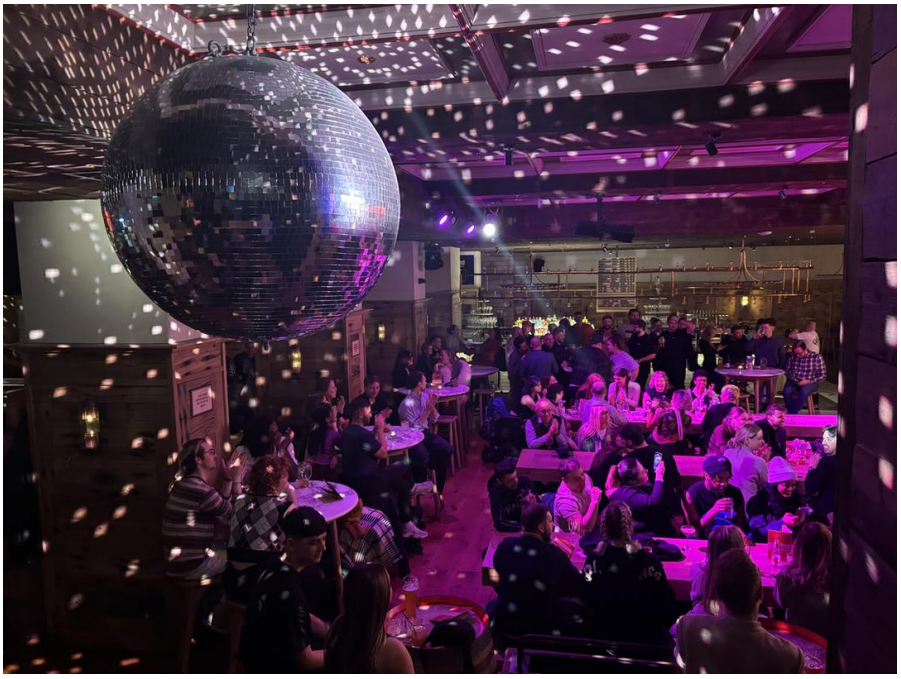
At another event, I was in a conversation circle with four people: myself, a startup founder promoting a new drink product, a real estate saleswoman, and a small business owner in the natural gas industry. The man with the energy company began handing out his business cards, but when he was about to give one to me, he paused and said, "You probably don't need me — I can't see a link between us. no need to waste a card, right?" He didn't finish the sentence, and quietly slid the card back into his LV handbag. It was tucked under his arm. He wore a grey shirt, visibly darker under his arms where he had been sweating in the overheated room. With a black napkin, he kept wiping the sweat from his forehead, leaving behind small bits of black lint that matched his black tie.

We kept talking. The startup founder asked the real estate agent questions about buying land, and she shared some useful advice. The startup said, "Great! I didn't expect to get this kind of help tonight." Maybe because of this conversation, the man suddenly pulled a business card from his bag again. "Maybe your area has nothing to do with mine. But who knows? Maybe I run into something that needs social

science in someday?" He paused, then added, "Oh, maybe I'll expand my business to China." Yes, it was my past experience in China that earned me this card now.

I asked him, "Why do you come to networking events?"

He shrugged and opened his hands. "You never know who will give you some useful information in the future. You never know." Then he gave me a sly smile — and handed me the card that had been waiting in his hand the whole time.

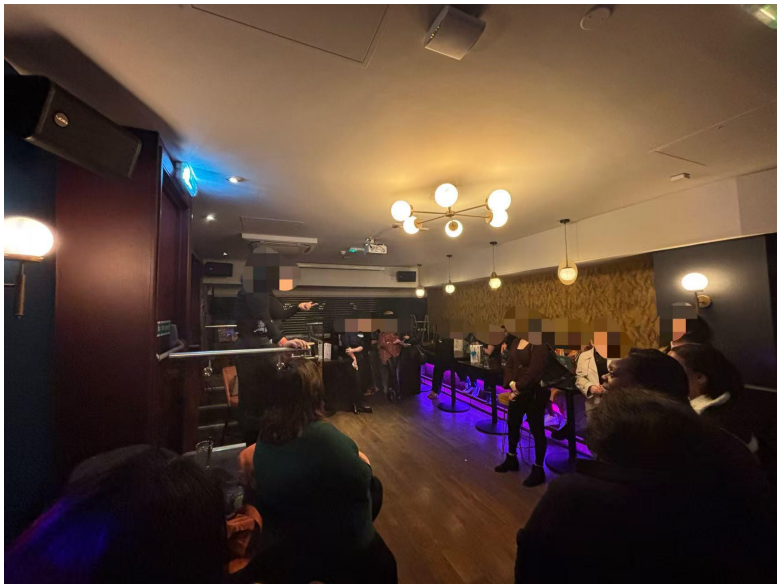







HOC
HAN OF CHIANG






ETERNAL HALO


ERDINGER
WEISSBRÄU

(Some images were captured by the author, while others were provided to participants by the event organizers.)

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